

Alphabetical order

ALPHABETICAL ORDER IS A SIMPLE WAY OF ORGANIZING GROUPS OF WORDS.

From a short list of students in a classroom to a long index in a book, alphabetical order makes information easy to store and find.

Sorting a list

Alphabetical order is the arranging of words based on where their initial letters are in the alphabet. Using this system, words are sorted by their first letters, then by their second letters, and so on. For example, the words *buy* and *biscuit* both begin with the letter *b*, but the second letter in each word is different: The letter *i* in *biscuit* comes before the letter *u* in *buy*, so *biscuit* would come before *buy* in an alphabetical list.

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- If a long word has the same letters as a short word, but then goes further—such as *cave* and *caveman*—the **short word (e.g. cave) will always come first** in a dictionary.
- The alphabet is **useful for locating a seat** in a theater or a book in a library, as rows are usually labeled in alphabetical order.

